



Mandrillus sphinx

Mandrill



Location W. Central Africa

Length 18–33 in
(45–83 cm)

Tail 2–5 in
(5–12.5 cm)

Weight 14–60 lb
(6.5–27 kg)

Social unit Group

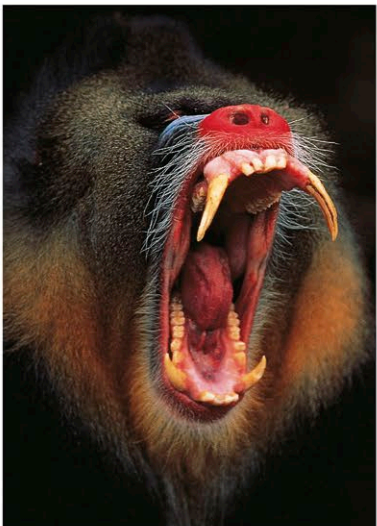
Status Vulnerable



A scarlet nose with prominent, bony blue flanges on either side are the unmistakable characteristics of the male mandrill. The female's facial color is much more subdued. She is about a third of the size of the male, which, at 23½ in (60 cm) high to the shoulder, is the largest of all monkeys. Mandrills live in groups in dense African rain forest, spending most of their day on the ground looking for fruit and seeds, as well as eggs and small animals. When night falls, they take to the trees for safety. Troops move over a range of up to 20 square miles (50 square km); they mark their territory with scent and defend it against rivals. Much of what is known about this species comes from studies of captive animals; in the wild, hunted for meat, and with its habitat being destroyed by logging, the mandrill is becoming increasingly scarce.

BOLD ADVERTISEMENT

With his spectacularly colored face—scarlet nose with blue flanges, and yellow beard—the mandrill boldly declares his identity to other animals in the forest. Together with his mauve-blue rump, these colors also announce the male's sex and display his virility to females.



A WARNING YAWN

When threatened by a predator or approached by rivals, the male will yawn widely to reveal his fearsome teeth, which can be 2½ in (6.5 cm) long.



LIFE ON THE GROUND

The mandrill walks and runs on all fours—a form of locomotion made all the more efficient by having fore- and hindlimbs of nearly equal length.

MANDRILL SOCIETY

In the past, wild mandrills were thought to have a multi-level social structure like Hamadryas baboons and geladas, with units of one male and several females. But recent findings tell a different story. They are mostly seen in hordes of a few hundred individuals, but the adult males remain solitary and reside in these groups only during the mating season.



MOTHER AND CHILD

The mandrill gives birth to one offspring every 18 months or so. At first, the mother will carry the infant on her belly, but as it grows heavier, it will ride through the forest on her back.

FORAGING PARTY

Mandrills often forage in small parties, grunting constantly to stay in touch. When it is time to move on, the dominant male will round up his group with a 2-phase grunt or roar.



MALE AND FEMALE

The male is much larger than the female, with a far more colorful face. They generally live in very large, stable groups, although they may split up into smaller groups temporarily.

